How do you think the expansion of the spice trade set the stage for a new world?

Spices were always an important part of India's trade. Spices were traded with **Mesopotamia, China, Sumeria, Egypt and Arabia,** along with perfumes and textiles as far back as **7000 years ago** much before the Greek and Roman civilisations. Indian epics and in writings dating back to the **Roman Empire** in the 1st century AD(CE) talk about the cloves. Thousands of years ago the great masters of Ayurveda had listed the use of spices for cooking and in medicines.

While these spices are readily available today, there was a time when people risked their lives to get Indian spices. During the Middle Ages, a pound of ginger was worth the price of a sheep. A pound of mace was equal to the price of three sheep or half the price of a cow. Pepper was the crown jewel of all spices.

What are those spices that the world wanted so badly?

Cardamom, cloves, ginger, mace and nutmeg were some of the other spices that left Indian shores to flavour the world's kitchen.

Using spices in cooking has a long history. It may go back as far as 52,000 years ago. Though we cannot know for sure how men came to use spices, it is quite possible that it was by chance. However, spices have played a vital role in our food now for a long time. In earlier centuries, spices were not easily available and were very expensive. Thus, spice traders became rich. Pepper and cinnamon no longer cost a fortune. However, while they seem to have lost their glory and value, they will never lose their place in a kitchen. Especially an Indian one!

Black Pepper

Black pepper also known as 'Black gold' was the most prized spice traded from the Kerala coast. Indians have been using black pepper for a very long time. Farmers began growing it around 5000 years ago and exported it to North and West Asia. The trade soon spread to Greece, Rome, Europe, and China, and also became popular in the Islamic Empire. Recipes from rich Roman households show the value of the spice in ancient Rome. The Romans sent 120 ships a year from Egypt to trade with India and bring back enormous quantities of pepper.

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